US flights grounded for hours by an air traffic control failure

For more than four hours on Friday, no plane could take off in the United States. Officials blame old equipment overloaded by an upgrade, and say they see no sign of an attack.

Level 2 · B1 · 247 words · 11.8 words per sentence · 11 glossed

On Friday, November 13, the US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) ordered a ground stop for the whole country. More than 3,500 planes were already in the air and could land, but planes on the ground could not take off. It was only the second nationwide ground stop since the attacks of September 11, 2001.

The stop began at 3:54 p.m. Eastern Time, after problems with communications between air traffic control centers. The FAA called it a "temporary telecommunications outage". It ended at 8:15 p.m.

More than 15,000 flights were affected. By the evening, FlightAware counted more than 6,700 cancellations. Flights to and from Europe and Canada were also hit. On Saturday, more than 2,000 flights were already canceled, and Duffy said it will take some time for schedules to return to normal.

Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said that old routers "got overloaded with data" and began to give inconsistent information, so the FAA shut the system down as a safety step. Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin said that new security patches seemed to overwhelm the old system. Duffy asked Congress for $50 billion to modernize air traffic control.

Officials said they saw no sign of a cyberattack so far, but Mullin said that nothing was completely certain, and the investigation continues. He also said that there was no connection to the Microsoft outage. Some air traffic controllers are not convinced by the official explanation.

Why does it matter? One old system can stop a whole country, and the effects last longer than the failure itself.

GLOSSARY

ground stop	parada total: nenhum avião pode decolar
telecommunications	telecomunic comunic di
outage	pane, interrupção de um serviço
routers	roteadores, aparelhos que direcionam os dados
inconsistent	inconsistentes, que não combinam entre si
patches	atualizações de correção de um sistema
overwhelm	sobrecarregar, ser demais para
modernize	modernizar, atualizar
cyberattack	ataque cibernético, feito por hackers
controllers	controladores de tráfego aéreo
convinced	convencidos

FRIDAY, IN EASTERN TIME	
3:36 p.m.	Radar and communications become unstable, according to Duffy.
3:54 p.m.	The FAA orders a ground stop for all departures. More than 3,500 planes are in the air.
8:15 p.m.	The FAA lifts the ground stop, after more than four hours.
8:30 p.m.	Duffy and Mullin explain what happened at a news conference at the White House.
Saturday	More than 2,000 flights are canceled, and schedules are still recovering.

Sources: Notebookcheck and Benzinga for the early times, ABC News, NBC News and Gizmodo for the rest. The times are the ones in the reports.

What we know, and what we do not

The investigation was still open on Saturday, November 14. This table keeps what officials and reports confirm apart from what is still unknown.

	CONFIRMED	NOT KNOWN YET
THE STOP	The FAA stopped all departures at 3:54 p.m. Eastern Time and lifted the order at 8:15 p.m. Planes already in the air could land.	When flights and schedules will be fully normal. Duffy says it will take time.
THE CAUSE	Duffy says old routers were overloaded with data and gave inconsistent information. Mullin says new security patches seemed to overwhelm them.	Independent confirmation. The investigation continues, and some controllers are not convinced.
A CYBERATTACK?	Officials say there is no evidence of one so far.	A final answer. Mullin said that nothing was completely certain yet.
MICROSOFT	Mullin said there is no connection to the Microsoft outage.	Nothing public shows a link, in either direction.
THE EFFECTS	More than 15,000 flights were affected. By the evening, FlightAware counted more than 6,700 cancellations. More than 2,000 flights were canceled for Saturday.	How many travelers were affected in total.
THE MONEY	Duffy asked Congress for $50 billion to modernize air traffic control.	Whether Congress will approve it.

Sources: ABC News, CBS News, NBC News, CNN, CBC News, Newsweek. Situation on Saturday, November 14, 2026. The cause is still under investigation.

AFTER READING

1. Why did the FAA stop all departures in the US?
2. What explanation did Duffy and Mullin give?
3. What do officials say about a cyberattack and the Microsoft outage?

TALK ABOUT IT

4. Have you ever had a flight canceled or delayed? What did you do while you waited?
5. Why would officials stop all flights, even when only some systems are failing?
6. Duffy asked Congress for $50 billion to modernize air traffic control. How should a government decide when to replace old systems?
7. Some controllers are not convinced by the official explanation. What would you want to see before you believed it?

SOURCES

ABC News, Nationwide ground stop lifted after more than 4 hours as Trump administration blames old, overloaded tech

CBS News, FAA lifts nationwide ground stop that disrupted thousands of flights, White House says no indication of "nefarious act"

NBC News, Ground stop lifted hours after stranding thousands of flights across the U.S.

CNN, November 13, 2026 — Some US flights resume after hours-long ground stop

CBC News, U.S. flights cleared to take off again after ground stop order caused thousands of delays and cancellations

Newsweek, FAA Issues National Ground Stop Citing Extraordinary Circumstance, Safety Reasons